should be deferred. He spoke to his friend once again, and the matter was laid to rest. A few days later, we mobilized for the scheduled operational rehearsal and moved to our staging area near Chhangu Lake, somewhere closer towards Nathu La, at a height of about 10,000 feet. It was about end September–early October and already bitterly cold, with a faint dusting of snow on the mountain tops. In the snow tent that was our Mess, Col Kapur came in one evening waving two posting orders, both for me, to two different places. He was fuming, because despite his request, not one but two postings had been issued, albeit by different sections of the MS branch, one as GSO 3 (Int) to 12 Corps and the other as training officer to the Regimental Centre. Talk about the right hand not knowing what the left hand was doing. Showing me both the orders, he had asked me for my choice but in all fairness, never tried to cancel either of them. I had said then that I would go wherever he felt was best, and after a moment's reflection, he said that I should go to the Centre. I was a little disappointed; GSO 3 (Int) was the more glamorous appointment, but having put my fate in his hands, I accepted his decision, which I have never regretted.

I handed over the house to Captain Ashok Sahrawat but continued to stay with him and his wife Usha and daughter Mamta, who was about two years old at the time, and made ready to depart. I was feeling a bit under the weather one day; I had excused myself and was fast asleep in the guest bedroom when Usha knocked on the door and handed me a slip of paper with a single word 'Kxxxxh'. I groaned in disbelief—not today of all days, gimme a break. But there it was and I had no choice but to change into uniform because all the activities that revolved around that code-word required my presence.

In November 1986, the Indian Army launched Operation Brasstacks, part of a series of exercises to simulate the operational

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